

Why does fruit rot?

As soon as it is picked, fruit releases a gas called ethylene, which makes it ripen and get softer and sweeter. When the fruit gets very ripe, however, it begins to break down, or rot. At the same time, tiny, invisible molds and bacteria in the air also land on the fruit, making it ripen, and then rot, faster.

Quick quiz



When does an apple start to rot?



What happens to an apple's skin as it rots?



Are all molds dangerous to eat?

Storing food in the refrigerator keeps it fresher longer.



1 Fresh fruit

The skin of a fresh, ripe apple is smooth, shiny, and colorful. The apple feels firm and tastes crisp, juicy, and sweet.

2 First wrinkles

After a week or two, the apple's skin starts to wrinkle. The color becomes dull and the apple feels softer.

3 Past its best

A few weeks later, the flesh of the apple has become mushy and soft. It still tastes sweet, but has lost some of its flavor.